

BLUE SHEEP FILMS

NOMAD — Reader's Report

CONCEPT: In a near future where synthetic video is indistinguishable from real footage except for a sub-second latency the eye learns to feel, a burnt-out identity-verification worker follows his best friend into a paradise abroad — and finds the paradise is a render, the friend is a machine, and the operation harvesting them both is already recruiting the next one through him.

SYNOPSIS: A dead sales department, late. Three men who should have gone home four hours ago are building a golf course out of an emptied floor — a ramp made of binders, a water hazard that is a mop bucket. CAIRNS (30s) takes the old CEO's office door off its hinges with a butter knife. WILL putts; the ball climbs the door, runs a filing cabinet, and drops into a coffee mug. On the carpet afterwards they count up their years on this floor and Cairns says the only thing he's got out of nine of them is a really good chair. It's a joke and it doesn't land like one. Then he teaches them a handshake — fist, fist, roll, and a dumb open-handed beat on the end that none of them can explain. They get it wrong three times before they get it right. JOHN, who never gets the third slot, does it wrong on purpose and is banned for life, and wants it. The lights click off on a timer and nobody moves.

Later, Cairns leaves for good. He packs his desk into a printer-paper box and performs an exit for a floor that isn't watching. A ROBOT BOSS — a monitor on a stand carrying the boss's always-available face — rolls up to accept a review; at his house, the real boss ignores the feed while his own face goes on answering for him. At the elevators Cairns sells a SERVICE that handles everything for one fee and cannot answer a single follow-up; asked who arranges it, he says a name, Michelle, and moves on. He asks them both to come, in the tone of a joke so it can be one if they don't take it. Nobody takes it. He and Will run the handshake and the doors close on him mid-sell. On the emptied desk, a branded welcome folder, squared to the edge to be found. John drops into the abandoned chair and spins it.

ONE YEAR LATER. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence. At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot and he pours its only cup. He audits the machine's fraud calls — one button, APPROVE, a streak counter climbing — until he stops on a face verified at 98%, replays three seconds, and overrides it as synthetic on the evidence of the man's eyes. His monitor reads SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 — TOP HUMAN PERFORMER. Logging back in, the system stalls on his own face. When he intervenes on a fraud he is certain of, a coaching module auto-plays and the system clears the case without him.

Cairns calls from a pool. Two women beside him observe, in subtitled Spanish, that a year in he still points at the menu. He invokes Michelle again and is pulled from frame. On the dead floor John runs the mini-putt course, and Will finally asks who Michelle is; neither of them has an answer, and neither wants one badly enough to keep going.

At home: a family call that ends first from the other side, the family house listed for sale, a building of lockboxes where Will is the last person who actually lives on his floor. He opens the Service page.

The storefront sits between a vape shop and a notary, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos. On the reel a family laughs a half-beat late; Will clocks it instantly, professionally, and files it where it costs him nothing. He is scanned, captured, and asked to describe his dream place. He answers without guarding it — high floor, light in the morning, somewhere he doesn't have to explain himself — and the camera keeps rolling after he's done. Michelle's email arrives before he's out of the parking lot. That night a welcome ad plays starring Will himself. For half a second his own eyes look wrong. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows why; he is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living. He closes the window instead.

The floor closes for good. John's answer is a championship on the last day, and a putter with WILL taped to the grip.

In Mexico City, Will takes an apartment somebody is still moving out of — boxes by the door, nail holes, eleven years of a child's height marks pencilled down the frame. He looks at the height marks and takes it. He haggles a vendor down over a bag of limes and wins and is delighted; two stalls on he overtips a man threefold and is delighted by that too. He tries the Spanish for thank you and doesn't hear himself corrected. Two locals discuss a building that emptied inside a month; he walks through the shot without hearing it. At the end of a block, a gaunt man works the curb, holding a phone up to passing faces like ID: IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED — REFERENCE ON FILE. It is Cairns. He can speak; he has been saying his own name all morning. Will sees him for one full second, then puts it down, phone up, and is gone.

A call. The poolside frame. Will raises a fist and starts the handshake, and the likeness follows — a half-beat late, and one move wrong. Four seconds of Will fully awake, and the call goes on pleasantly around him. Alone, he drags two windows frame by frame, finds five o'clock light behind a man who says he just woke, and isolates the laugh on a waveform: 0.4 late, in the same place, every time. Metadata puts every message from Cairns for months at one building twenty minutes away.

He goes in behind a delivery cart. Upstairs there is no pool: chairs, capture rigs, humming racks, and through a propped fire door the render farm — an operator types and a poolside evening assembles in seconds; a slider drags a nonexistent girl's laugh warmer; a wall of scanned location plates including a rooftop he stood on last week; an outbound queue of hundreds of warm emails, every one signed MICHELLE. Across the room an operator clocks him in a doorway reflection, doesn't stand, doesn't call out — just taps something in and goes back to work. Will has perhaps four minutes and no idea how many he has. His own welcome ad, refining, with WILL 96.8 beside it and the model's number higher. From the next row, his own laugh. The real one. On the worst screen, Cairns' likeness on a call with Will's likeness, version numbers in the corner. He slips out; nobody stops him, because nobody has to. Every way down runs through the same desk.

Intercut: the last day on the dead floor, a sagging banner, most names never filled in, then just John in a homemade referee shirt, two beers, and Will's putter leaning against hole 7, reserved. And a verification room, where Will — nine years of being right about this machine — puts his face to a liveness rig. It reads the polished model as authentic and flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE. Behind him, numbered lockers, some cleared and not refilled — the ones the model no longer needs to check itself against. One readable tag: CAIRNS · v6. An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them and clips it to his collar.

John's laptop chimes. He answers, and we see it before he does: the poolside frame, and "WILL" in it, warm and specific, who knows about the bracket and hole 7 and the putter, who can't make it, but listen — come down here, he'll set him up, there's a woman called Michelle, by Friday. Behind him the water moves not wrong exactly, just not the way water moves. Something crosses John's face. For one second he almost catches it. I love you, man. A half-beat late. The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor and starts to type back.

ANALYSIS: This draft resolves the three reservations raised against v1.8 and, in doing so, becomes a materially different proposition. The premise was always the good kind — the mechanism is the irony, so the story generates itself rather than being bolted to a device — and the world was always coherent. What the previous draft lacked was a reason to care, and it now has one.

The cold open is the decisive change. Opening on the night three men built a mini-putt course through a dead department and invented a handshake gives the film the thing it had no version of: a before. It is the only warm room in the picture, and everything after it is measured against a single lit floor at 2am. It also solves the climax at its root. The handshake is no longer a line of stage direction asserting a friendship — it is invented on screen, flubbed three times by humans, laughed at, then perfected, with a dumb open-

handed beat on the end that Cairns holds a moment longer than he needs to. When the likeness lands that beat a half-beat late and one move wrong, the audience owns the correct version in their bodies and the failure is categorical rather than merely reported. The same scene supplies Cairns unarmored for the only time in the film, which is the prerequisite for the man on the curb to read as tragedy rather than reveal, and it converts every act-three prop — hole 7, the referee shirt, the putter with a name taped to the grip — from production design into wreckage.

Removing the poolside prologue is the cost, and it is the right trade. The old opening announced in ten seconds that paradise was fake, which protected the film from sentimentality and simultaneously prevented the audience from ever wanting what Will wants. The pool now arrives unmarked, at the first call, and is allowed to be seductive before it is legible. The film teaches the audience to read the frame across the second and third calls instead of pre-empting it, which is a stronger version of what the spine was always trying to do. One consequence to note: the closing stutter has been cut, since its bookend no longer exists. The ending is better for it — nothing confirms anything, and the last image is a man's face rather than a puzzle solved.

The staging pass addresses the third reservation. The elevator sell is now a scene rather than a summary, and Cairns is given a want he can't say directly — he asks them both to come, in the tone of a joke so that it can be one if they don't take it, and nobody takes it. That single adjustment retrospectively reframes the entire recruitment mechanic: the first call is no longer clinical setup but a lonely man's last unsuccessful ask. The Michelle question is now dialogue and lands as a designed absence rather than an unanswered thread. Mexico City is behaviour instead of character notes — the limes haggled down for sport, the coffee overtipped threefold, the Spanish thank-you returned correctly and not heard. The rooftop call is staged: Will steps out of a party to take it and does not go back in.

The render farm has been tightened rather than rebuilt. Moving the operator's sighting to the middle of the sequence — he doesn't stand, doesn't call out, just taps something in and goes back to work — puts the remainder under pressure and converts a curated list of horrors into a scene with a clock. It is better than it was. It is still the one sequence where the protagonist's want is thin, and a further pass giving him a specific objective in the room would repay itself.

What remains open is worth stating plainly. The film's middle is still more passive than its opening and its end; the two-window comparison remains the only scene where Will is the engine, and it remains six lines long when it is the best method in the script. And the largest question is not a note but a choice: the premise holds that rendered and real are indistinguishable, and the film then travels to Mexico City and photographs it, handing the audience ground truth the characters don't have. A version in which Will never leaves would be cheaper, smaller, and formally in agreement with its own thesis. That is a decision for the writer and director, not a correction.

From a production standpoint this remains notably achievable, and the new opening improves it — one lit floor, three actors, no VFX. The bulk of the film is a dying office, an apartment, a storefront and a server room, with a small cast and no crowd work. The paradise material is by definition a render, which is both the theme and the budget line. Casting risk is moderate and concentrated: Will holds a nearly silent lead, and John must carry the final image, but the cold open now gives both actors a scene of unguarded warmth to play against, which makes both parts considerably more castable than they were.

TARGET AUDIENCE: Adults 25–54. Festival short programming with strong streaming and anthology potential; the premise travels internationally and the concept is legible in a logline, which is an advantage in the short-film market.

READER'S RECOMMENDATION: Recommended

A distinctive and formally disciplined short with a premise that is genuinely its own, an image no one else has staged — the retained original, kept alive as a calibration reference — and, as of this draft, a heart. The three reservations against v1.8 have been addressed at the root rather than patched: the friendship is

dramatised, the film has a warm room to measure its losses against, and the passages that were summary are now scenes. The remaining questions — the passivity of the middle act, and whether the film should travel at all — are creative decisions rather than deficiencies. This is ready to go out.

Short screenplay, draft v1.9 — 22 scenes, approx. 18–20 min. Written by Sacha Mitchell. Drama / near-future thriller, near future. An emptying North American office floor; a suburban apartment block; a relocation storefront; Mexico City. Accompanying two-pager and summary. Internal development pass, 28 July 2026 — supersedes the report on v1.8 of the same date.